

Part II – Comparative State Shortlist (Fronts 1 + 3)

Below is a ranked/tiered shortlist of five states whose models go beyond civics knowledge into civic participation, organizing capacity, and community power, with explicit attention to equity. All are strong candidates for Weeks 3–4 comparative analysis.

Tier 1: Massachusetts

What makes it strong

- 2018 History and Social Science Framework created a full-year 8th-grade civics course and embedded inquiry-based learning, "taking informed action," and SEL across PreK–12.
- "An Act to Promote and Enhance Civic Engagement" (2018) requires at least one student-led, nonpartisan civics project in both middle and high school and established the Civics Project Trust Fund (~\$1.5M annually) to support implementation, especially in underserved districts.

Hands-on/participatory

- Projects must be student-led, standards-aligned, and focused on real community issues, culminating in authentic civic actions (e.g., testimony, campaigns, public information efforts), not just classroom simulations.
- DESE's Civics Project Guidebook provides detailed guidance on project phases, community partnerships, simulations, and assessment, effectively functioning as a state "how-to" manual for action civics.

Equity & access

- The Civics Project Trust Fund prioritizes districts with higher proportions of low-income and EL students, and CIRCLE's study suggests this targeted funding has helped reduce resource gaps in civics implementation, though access is still uneven, especially at the elementary level.

Youth organizing/leadership

- Youth coalitions such as Teens Leading the Way and the Massachusetts Civic Learning Coalition were instrumental in passing the law and now advise on equitable implementation; this is a clear example of youth organizing shaping statewide policy.
- The framework and guidebook elevate student voice, collaborative decision-making, and leadership roles throughout the project cycle, consistent with building organizing capacity.

Programs/structures to profile

- Massachusetts civics law + Civics Project Trust Fund (policy + funding model).
- DESE Civics Project Guidebook (implementation playbook for student-led action projects).

Tier 1: Illinois

What makes it strong

- 2015 Illinois civics law requires a semester-long high-school civics course incorporating four evidence-based practices: instruction on government institutions, discussion of current/controversial issues, service learning through informed action, and simulations of democratic processes; later legislation extended civics mandates to middle school.
- ISBE implementation guidance reiterates these practices, frames inquiry as the learning mode, and allows local flexibility on where to place the course, while CIRCLE's multi-year evaluation underscores Illinois as a model of state-policy-driven systemic change.

Hands-on/participatory

- Service learning and simulations are statutory components, making informed action and democratic process practice part of the core course, not optional enrichment.
- Chicago Public Schools' earlier move from hours-based to project-based service learning, in partnership with Mikva Challenge and other youth-organizing groups, provided a proof of concept for integrating action civics into core instruction and shaped statewide implementation.

Equity & access

- Illinois Democracy Schools support whole-school, cross-disciplinary civic learning agendas emphasizing youth voice and equitable opportunities; over 80 high schools serving 100,000+ students are recognized.
- Guardians of Democracy micro-credentials provide scalable PD on civic pedagogies to teachers across the state, an important capacity-building and equity mechanism.

Youth organizing/leadership

- Democracy Schools require working groups that explicitly include students, giving them a direct role in redesigning civic learning structures and practices in their schools.
- Action-civics partners (e.g., Mikva Challenge) embed youth in authentic campaigns, hearings, and school governance, directly building organizing and nonviolent civic action skills.

Programs/structures to profile

- Illinois civics law + ISBE guidance (codified evidence-based civic pedagogies).
- Illinois Democracy Schools + Guardians of Democracy (school-wide framework and teacher-capacity model).

Tier 1: Rhode Island

What makes it strong

- The 2021 Civic Literacy Act requires all public high-school graduates to demonstrate civics proficiency (locally defined) and mandates that every student complete at least one standards-aligned, student-led civics project in middle or high school.

- A Civic Readiness Task Force defines "civic readiness" (knowledge, skills, experiences, mindsets), recommends characteristics of student-led projects, and advises on civics courses and capstone design, creating a governance structure around implementation.

Hands-on/participatory

- Student-led projects must promote reasoning with evidence and understanding links between federal, state, and local policies and issues affecting students' communities, leading to concrete civic actions.
- RIDE's Civic Learning Guidebook details civic learning practices and civic action projects (Taking Informed Action and civics capstones), including project phases, scope and timelines, assessment strategies, inclusivity requirements, and suggestions for culminating events.

Equity & access

- Advocates argue that only a statewide half-credit civics requirement plus a high-school-level project will ensure equitable implementation; petitions to RIDE explicitly frame equity and uniformity as central to the law's intent.
- The planned Diploma Seal of Civic Readiness and middle-school recognition program provide additional, potentially equity-focused levers to incentivize and highlight robust civic learning, though much depends on implementation.

Youth organizing/leadership

- Student plaintiffs and youth advocates helped drive the underlying civics litigation and settlement; follow-on programs like the Rhode Island Civic Leadership Program require participants to design and execute civic action projects (voter registration drives, engagement clubs, youth poll worker recruitment) and earn a civic excellence certificate.
- The law's explicit focus on student-led projects and planned statewide civics showcases institutionalized youth leadership and public presentation of civic work.

Programs/structures to profile

- Rhode Island Civic Literacy Act + Civic Readiness Task Force (compact law + governance model).
- RIDE Civic Learning Guidebook and Civic Readiness Seal (K–12 practice framework and recognition structure).

Tier 1.5: California

What makes it strong

- California's 2016 History–Social Science Framework integrates civics throughout K–12 and adds a half-year "Principles of American Democracy" course, alongside guidance on inquiry, disciplinary literacy, and civic engagement.
- The State Seal of Civic Engagement (SSCE) allows LEAs to recognize students who demonstrate civic knowledge and significant civic participation, with state criteria emphasizing excellence in both learning and action.

Hands-on/participatory

- SSCE criteria commonly require documented civic activities (e.g., school governance, advocacy, community problem-solving, service learning) plus reflective work, tying recognition to sustained, authentic civic practice, not single events.
- Deeper-learning community schools and Linked Learning academies, highlighted by LPI, integrate project-based civic and community-connected learning into pathways, often including internships, policy projects, and collaborations with local organizations.

Equity & access

- State guidance encourages LEAs to create SSCE "pathways" that are accessible across grade levels and diverse contexts, and to use data to track who earns the seal, supporting equity monitoring.
- Research on California deep-learning schools shows that when combined with adequate resources and wraparound supports, project-based, civic-connected learning can improve outcomes for students of color and low-income students.

Youth organizing/leadership

- Many SSCE pathways rely on student leadership in school climate initiatives, local issue campaigns, and governance structures, with state guidance emphasizing youth agency and collaboration across institutional partners.

Programs/structures to profile

- California State Seal of Civic Engagement (flexible, equity-oriented recognition framework for civic participation).
- Exemplars like Social Justice Humanitas Academy or Linked Learning community schools (rigorous academics + civic projects + community partnerships).

Tier 1.5: New York

What makes it strong

- New York's Seal of Civic Readiness recognizes students who demonstrate civic knowledge, skills, and participation, with a state-defined point system that includes options for civics capstones, advanced coursework, community service, and extracurricular civic activities.
- The Civic Readiness Initiative provides models and criteria for LEAs, an oversight committee, and toolkits to guide local civics capstones and seal implementation, making project-based civics structurally visible.

Hands-on/participatory

- Students can earn points through civics projects that require researching issues, engaging in civic action, and reflecting on impact, as well as through other structured civic activities.
- State guidance recommends embedding projects in coursework and producing public products, encouraging community-connected and participatory experiences.

Equity & access

- Learning Policy Institute lists New York among states that provide explicit models and criteria for civics capstones and seals, and encourages use of capstones for locally defined seals; this state-level support is intended to promote equitable access to meaningful civics pathways.
- The multi-pathway, point-based system can accommodate varied contexts and constraints (e.g., work responsibilities, limited extracurricular access) if LEAs design inclusive options.

Youth organizing/leadership

- While the seal itself is competency-focused, many districts are using capstone projects to support student-led community change efforts, advocacy, and partnerships, creating de facto organizing and leadership development opportunities within the civic readiness framework.

Programs/structures to profile

- New York Seal of Civic Readiness + capstone guidance (recognition + project model that could be adapted to Delaware).
- Civic capstone toolkit and oversight structure (state-level support for consistent, action-oriented projects).